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From the editor-in-chief

It is a story that is such a part of India's daily news that we don't even notice it anymore unless it involves famous people. Every day, there are road accidents in our country which kill hundreds of people. It is now officially established by the WHO's 2009 Global Status Report on Road Safety that India has more deaths in road accidents than any other country in the world. There are more deaths on India's roads than in terrorist attacks or natural disasters. According to the 2007 National Crime Records Bureau figures, it is estimated that 13 people die every hour due to road accidents in India. Every 10th person in the world who dies in a road accident is an Indian. These are alarming figures. India's economy is growing and the number of vehicles on our roads is increasing, but that is not the reason for such poor road safety.

India does not even have as many vehicles as the developed world, but its road fatalities are rising by 8 per cent per year. There are around 73 million vehicles in India and 470 million in the United States. The US may even have more road accidents than India does—6.4 million to India's total of 4,18,600—but the number of people that die due to accidents in the US totalled just above 42,000 in a year as opposed to India's 1,14,590.

This is a shocking difference but one that is almost inevitable given the state of the roads in our country, the people who drive on them and the enforcers of the law. We may celebrate the construction of expressways and flyovers but the fact that our cars can sometimes go quicker only means that they are more unsafe.

The lack of traffic management means accidents happen when cars share space with buses, cycles, pedestrians and bullock carts. The poor response of emergency services only lessens the chance of survival for the victims. Drivers buy licences rather than pass a test, so they don't know the rules, jump stop lights regularly and drive under the influence of alcohol. Nine out of 10 will not be fined severely which is why India's urban roads today are lawless. The WHO is right when it believes that road safety needs to be a public health issue rather than one merely of civil engineering.

Our cover story this week on India's killer roads was put together by Principal Correspondent Mihir Srivastava. He spoke to people involved in traffic, urban planning and government, all of whom need to find a way to alter this frightening situation.

To my mind the state of traffic and road behaviour reflects the way a city or a country operates. The fact that laws are not enforced, lights don't work and licensing is corrupt indicates a deeper malaise in a society. If we are able to fix our roads and traffic behaviour, we will be able to fix much else in this country.

(Aroon Purie)

